STATE SCAN

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PTI

NEW BEGINNINGS DMDK chief Premlatha Vijayakanth with CM M.K. Stalin and other DMK leaders

▶ TAMIL NADU

MASSING FOR THE BIG WAR

The late Vijayakanth to counter Vijay? The DMDK switch hit stirs up the Dravidian pot

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

TAMIL NADU IS HEADING INTO WHAT MAY BE ONE OF ITS MOST intriguing assembly election in recent times, with actor-turned-politician Vijay turning the fixed bipolarity of old into an unstable triangle, and looking primed to skim off fresh cream and settled malcontents from the electorate. The state has seen third fronts before, even some dramatic trial flights, but most ended in crash landings. The question in 2026 is whether Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) will gain altitude. This new variable has made alliance-making among the two traditional parties more consequential than ever, for each loop of needle and thread stitches up a bigger piece of the fabric.

The stirrings at the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) end are particularly interesting. Despite the anti-incumbency and the presence of a new challenger, chief minister M.K. Stalin is marshalling the 15-party Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) like a stern CEO. On one plane, a breakthrough is in sight after a tense sequence of negotia-